

ALLIANCE GAMES
(Clockwise) Mamata Banerjee with Akhilesh Yadav in UP; Arvind Kejriwal during the Punjab campaign; Rahul Gandhi at Amethi



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IN **2012, THE SAMAJWADI PARTY BAGGED** 227 of Uttar Pradesh's 403 assembly seats with just over 29 per cent of the vote share and formed the government. A decade later, the party increased its vote share to 32 per cent, but could win only 111 seats, failing to pose any significant challenge to the BJP, which has retained over 40 per cent vote share in the past four polls in the state—the 2014 and 2019 general elections, and the 2017 and 2022 assembly polls.

This absolute dominance of the saffron party in India's most politically significant state, which elects 80 Lok Sabha MPs, indicates the magnitude of the challenge opposition parties face. That the incumbent BJP is set to form the government in UP, Uttarakhand, Goa and Manipur underscores the fact that the opposition parties failed to match its organisational strength and narrative, despite discontent triggered by the adverse economic impact of the Covid pandemic.

The only glimmer of hope for the Opposition is AAP's landslide victory in Punjab, with 92 seats in the 117-member house. It makes AAP the only non-BJP, non-Congress party to be in power in more than one state. Speculation has now begun over the possibility of Arvind Kejriwal leading an opposition alliance in 2024. Those in favour of this proposition claim that the Punjab win proves Kejriwal's credentials as a leader with acceptance beyond Delhi.

There are many hurdles, however, in the way of AAP becoming the fulcrum of opposition unity, with no consensus yet on the structure and leadership of any proposed anti-BJP alliance. There have been several contenders, from West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee to Telangana CM K. Chandrashekar Rao. The Congress, the only national party in the Opposition, still sees itself as the pivot of any alliance. "There can't be an Opposition without Congress, given its pan-India presence," says a member of the Congress Working Committee.

A similar narrative had emerged after the TMC's 2021 victory in Bengal. Mamata was projected as the leader around whom the Opposition could rally in 2024. She visited several opposition leaders, including Kejriwal, NCP chief Sharad Pawar and Maharashtra CM Uddhav Thackeray. In a bid to expand its national footprint, her party aggressively participated in the Goa elections, but ended up drawing a blank. AAP's Punjab success, however, could paradoxically provide the Bengal-based party a model to experiment with in other states and eventually challenge AAP at its own game. "AAP took almost 10 years to win Punjab. We started expanding only after 2021. Let's see